Errors Are Not Choke Points: Where LLM Failures Are Decided, and Why Restarting Is Hard to Beat

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Abstract

Verifier-guided search, process reward models and hallucination-repair loops share one assumption: a failing generation goes wrong at an identifiable step, and resampling from just before that step is better than starting over. We test this assumption end to end, on mathematical reasoning and on retrieval-augmented generation, with a single quantity: v_k, the generator's own probability of success from prefix k, measured by on-policy resampling.

Detection. On 3,400 ProcessBench traces, early-warning detectors mostly read difficulty: question and generator alone reach AUROC 0.588, and a quarter of the reasoning adds +0.005 (n.s.).

Commitment. From 125,832 continuations of four open models, value curves replicate across independent batches ($r = 0.985$). 33–66% of failures are decided before the first step. When the outcome is still open, the human-labelled first error is where success collapses in 0.438–0.647 of traces (null ≈0.18; preregistered and confirmed on a held-out model family).

Localisation. We release ChokeBench, which grades step localisers on both targets. A validated process reward model finds the human first error in 73% of open failures but the choke point in only 45%.

Recovery. No deployable resampling point reliably beats restart. At a matched end-to-end budget, PRM-guided backtracking is worse than restart (-0.063 on the preregistered model), and even an oracle that knows the choke point for free gains only +0.028 [+0.012, +0.046] at four restarts' budget. A supermartingale argument explains why. In RAG (RAGTruth, Llama-2-7B), a preregistered commitment-aware controller is equivalent to restarting until the detector passes, and its choice of where to resample adds -0.000 [-0.005, +0.005]. We also find that the apparent size of such recovery gains depends on the evaluator: +0.326 under an evaluator sharing the gate detector's training data, +0.017 (n.s.) under an independent judge.

Across both domains, restart is the baseline that local recovery must beat at matched compute, and it rarely is. All rollouts, preregistrations and the code behind every number are released.

1 Introduction

When a language model fails, test-time methods try to repair the failure rather than start over. Process reward models (PRMs) are trained and benchmarked to find the *first incorrect step* of a reasoning trace [2, 3, 5], and verifier-guided search backtracks to it. Early-warning detectors predict from a partial trace that the answer will be wrong [9, 10]. Retrieval-augmented systems detect a hallucinated sentence and rewrite or regenerate from there [33, 32]. All of these assume that a failure is *decided* at an identifiable step, and that resampling from just before that step beats resampling from scratch.

We test the assumption directly, with one quantity throughout. For a trace written by model M, let v_k be M's probability of reaching a correct (or faithful) output from the prefix ending at step k, estimated by sampling M's own continuations. v_0 is the from-scratch solve rate, so *restart* is resampling from $k = 0$ and *backtracking* to step j is resampling from $k = j - 1$. A *choke point* is where v collapses; an *error* is where a human annotator says the reasoning first goes wrong. The paper asks whether they coincide, whether existing signals can find either, and whether finding them pays for itself. The question is old in another guise: randomised search algorithms face the same choice between continuing a run and restarting it, and restarts are often optimal there [39, 40]. Language-model decoding is such a randomised search, and we find that the same answer holds.

Figure 1 summarises the answer in five panels, one per section that follows.

Every claim carries its evidence level (Section 3): PRE (preregistered before any data), EXP (exploratory) or CONF (a preregistered test on new data). Our contributions:

1. **Early warning is a difficulty signal** (EXP). On ProcessBench, question and generator alone predict a wrong answer with AUROC 0.588; the first quarter of the reasoning adds +0.005 (n.s.) and is at chance within a problem (0.485). 23.5% of first errors are not fatal.
2. **Counterfactual commitment at scale, with reliability checks.** 125,832 on-policy continuations from four models in two families; value curves replicate across independent batches ($r = 0.985$) and decisive steps are stable under posterior noise. 33–66% of failures are decided before the first step; among the rest, the labelled error is the choke point in 0.438–0.647 of traces against a null of 0.16–0.20 (PRE; CONF on Llama-3.1-8B, 0.633).

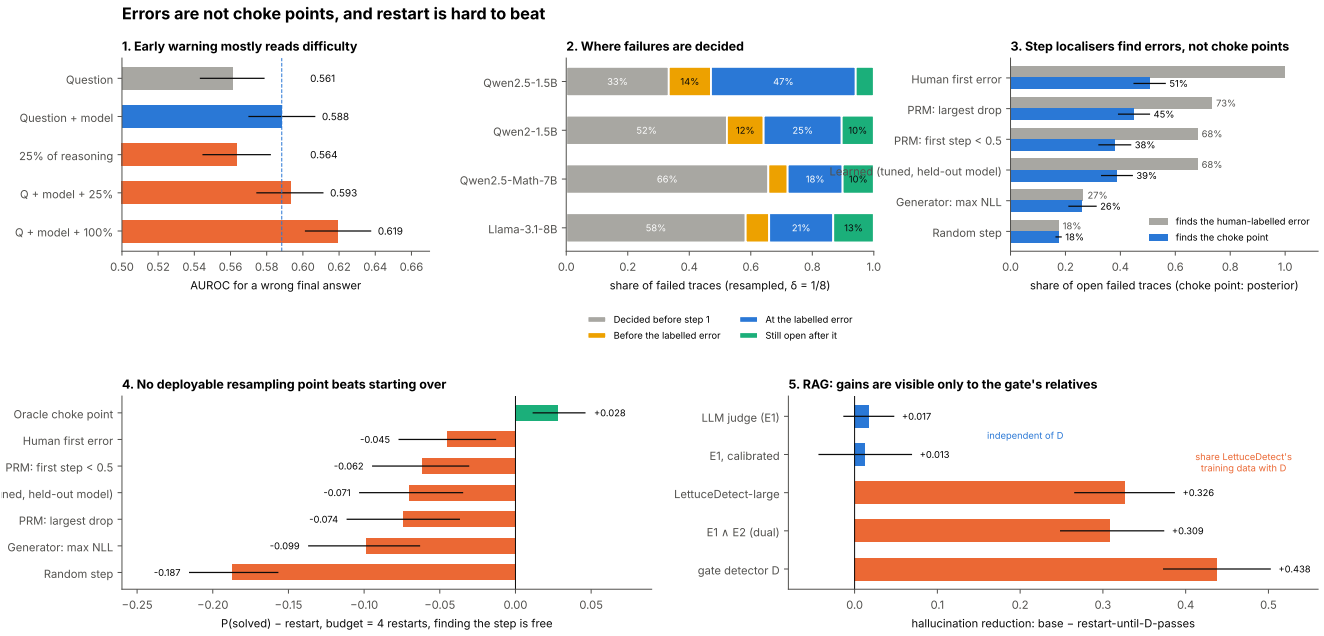


Figure 1: The study in one figure. (1) Early-warning detectors mostly read difficulty (Section 4). (2) Where failures of four generators are decided, from resampling (Section 5). (3) Step localisers find human-labelled errors, not choke points (Section 7). (4) No deployable resampling point beats restart at a matched budget, even with localisation free (Section 7). (5) In RAG, the measured gain of a detector-gated loop depends on whether the grader shares the detector's training data (Section 8).

3. **ChokeBench** (new). A benchmark that grades step localisers on the human first error *and* on the counterfactual choke point. The best PRM rule finds 73% of human first errors but 45% of choke points; on open failures no localiser, including the expert label or a localiser trained and tuned for the purpose, yields a better resampling point than the beginning.
4. **Restart is hard to beat at matched compute.** Charging every token, including verifier passes, PRM-guided backtracking loses to restart (-0.063, CONF); a free oracle for the choke point gains at most +0.028 at four restarts' budget. A short supermartingale argument shows why: a failed on-policy prefix chosen without looking ahead is, in expectation, worth no more than a fresh start.
5. **The same holds for hallucination recovery** (PRE). A commitment-aware RAG controller is equivalent to restart-until-the-detector-passes on RAGTruth, and its choice of where to resample adds -0.000 [-0.005, +0.005]. Hallucinations do not snowball.
6. **A measurement caution for detector-gated loops** (EXP). The reduction such a loop achieves looks +0.326 under an evaluator trained on the same data as the gate and +0.017 (n.s.) under an independent judge. Gains of a verifier loop should be measured by an evaluator that shares nothing with the verifier.

All code, rollouts, tables and the generator of every number in this paper are released.[1]

[1] https://github.com/HarshDubey23/early-failure-detection-cot

2 Related Work

Process supervision. Step-level supervision outperforms outcome supervision [2, 3]; Monte Carlo rollouts can label steps automatically [4], but such labels disagree with human judgements because a completion can reach the right answer from a wrong step and vice versa, which Zhang et al. [6] treat as label noise. ProcessBench [5] evaluates first-error identification. We study the disagreement itself.

Predicting failure early. Models carry information about their own correctness [22, 21], and hidden states predict CoT success before or during generation [9, 10]; conformal methods certify reasoning prefixes [20]. Bulut [11] shows that such pooled AUROCs are largely explained by problem difficulty and fall to chance within a problem. We apply the same control to text detectors on human-annotated traces.

Which steps matter. Resampling from prefixes identifies influential sentences [12], tokens [13, 14] and the importance of the first step [15]. Merrill and Srivastava [16] localise the point of no return for deceptive behaviour and name incorrect solutions as future work; recoverability of error states has been studied for distillation [17]. None compares a counterfactual decision point with human first-error labels. Work on performative CoT [18, 19] finds that answers are often fixed apart from the written reasoning, which our non-fatal errors echo.

Correcting and backtracking. Unaided self-correction rarely helps [8], but models can correct a mistake once told where it is [7], which motivates verifier-guided search that returns to the first error. Independent resampling from scratch,

as in self-consistency [23], is the natural baseline for any such scheme; we compare the two directly. Compute-matched comparisons of verifier-guided search with independent sampling are known to depend on difficulty and budget [29], and trained backtracking beats parallel best-of-n on deep search trees but not on shallow ones [36]. Bulut [11] compares truncated reasoning prefixes with matched-token restarts for two reasoning models and finds that long prefixes mostly buy the same successes more cheaply; we study *failed* traces, with expert error labels, four generators and verifier costs charged. Persistent-pool PRM search revisits discarded prefixes [37]; our results bound what any such revisiting can gain when the prefix belongs to a failed on-policy trace. Restart strategies for randomised search have a long theory [39, 40]; Appendix A gives the analogue for language-model decoding.

Hallucination recovery. Detect-then-revise systems rewrite unsupported claims [33] or verify and regenerate [32]; token-level detectors such as LettuceDetect [31], trained on RAGTruth [30], make the gate cheap. Hallucinations can snowball when a model commits to an early claim [35]; we test for this with human span labels and find no excess hazard. Resampling-based interpretability measures the importance of reasoning steps counterfactually [12, 38]; we apply the same tool to human error labels, verifiers and recovery policies.

3 Data and Definitions

Data. ProcessBench [5] contains 3,400 step-segmented solutions to GSM8K, MATH, OlympiadBench and Omni-MATH problems (2,842 distinct problems) from 12 open models, each with the index e of the first erroneous step (or none) and whether the final answer is correct. Correct and incorrect answers are balanced within each tier by construction.

Outcome groups. A trace is *clean* (no annotated error; 1,179), *recovered* (an error, but a correct answer; 521) or *fatal* (an error and a wrong answer; 1,700). No clean trace has a wrong answer. The *fatality* of first errors is $P(\text{wrong} \mid \text{error})$.

Counterfactual value. For a trace $T = (s_1, \ldots, s_n)$ written by model M, let $v_k = P_M(\text{correct} \mid q, s_{1:k})$, estimated by sampling m continuations of the prefix from M; v_0 is M's from-scratch solve rate and v_n is the observed outcome. The *decisive step* is $d = \arg\max_k(v_{k-1} - v_k)$, and the *point of no return* is $c = \min\{k : v_j \leq \delta \ \forall j \geq k\}$. A failing trace is *capability-limited* if $v_0 \leq \delta$, shows *latent commitment* if $c < e$, *commits at the error* if $c = e$, and has a *recoverable error* if $c > e$.

Evidence levels. The hypotheses H1–H4 of the counterfactual experiment (the commitment categories, the decisive step, sample-split backtracking, $\delta = 1/8$ with 1/16 and 1/4 as sensitivity) were committed before any rollout. Analyses added after seeing the Run A/B data (restart vs. first error, repeated splitting, the position-matched null) are *exploratory*. Before the confirmatory run (Run C) we committed a second plan (git commit `459ff22`; `docs/PREREGISTRATION_RUN_C.md`). It specified:

- tests C1–C4 on Llama-3.1-8B, a new family whose traces cover 479 new questions;
- measurement checks R1–R3 on three new independent sampling batches;
- the practical policies and their cost accounting.

Run C reached 144 of 274 Llama fatal traces within its 11.5-hour limit. Traces were processed in a random order, and recovered and clean traces were scheduled after the fatal ones, so none of those were run. All Run C deviations are reported in the text.

Table 1: AUROC for a wrong final answer (out-of-fold, 3,400 traces). Q: question text; G: generator and tier.

Detector	AUROC	95% CI	SD (5 seeds)
Q	0.561	0.543–0.578	0.005
G	0.539	0.521–0.557	0.002
Q+G	0.588	0.570–0.607	0.003
Prefix 25%	0.564	0.545–0.582	0.006
Prefix 100%	0.600	0.582–0.619	0.004
Q+G+prefix 25%	0.593	0.575–0.611	0.004
Q+G+prefix 50%	0.610	0.592–0.628	0.004
Q+G+prefix 100%	0.619	0.601–0.637	0.003
Trace length	0.542	0.524–0.561	0.002

Statistics. Detectors are TF-IDF (uni+bigrams) or one-hot features with logistic regression [28], cross-fitted over 5 folds grouped by problem and repeated over 5 seeds. Intervals are 95% question-level cluster bootstrap intervals [27] (1,000 resamples); differences between detectors use a paired bootstrap on the same traces.

4 Observational Results

4.1 Early failure prediction is a difficulty signal

Table 1 and Fig. 2 compare detectors that read the question, the generator and tier, the reasoning prefix, or combinations. The question alone reaches 0.561 and question plus generator 0.588 [0.570, 0.607]. A detector reading only the first 25% of the reasoning is *worse* than that (-0.025, $p = 0.012$), and adding the 25% prefix to question and generator changes AUROC by +0.005 [-0.004, +0.014]. The reasoning adds +0.022 at 50% and +0.031 [+0.020, +0.041] at 100%, consistently across all five seeds.

Within a problem the generator is the only varying factor besides the reasoning: over 326 problems with both a failing and a succeeding trace (466 pairs), the 25% prefix orders pairs correctly 0.485 of the time [0.440, 0.536] and the full prefix 0.539 [0.487, 0.589], neither better than generator identity alone (0.548). Early failure prediction on this benchmark is therefore almost entirely a statement about which problems are hard for which models.

4.2 One first error in four is not fatal

Fatality of first errors is 0.765 [0.748, 0.782]: 23.5% of annotated first errors are followed by a correct answer (Fig. 3).

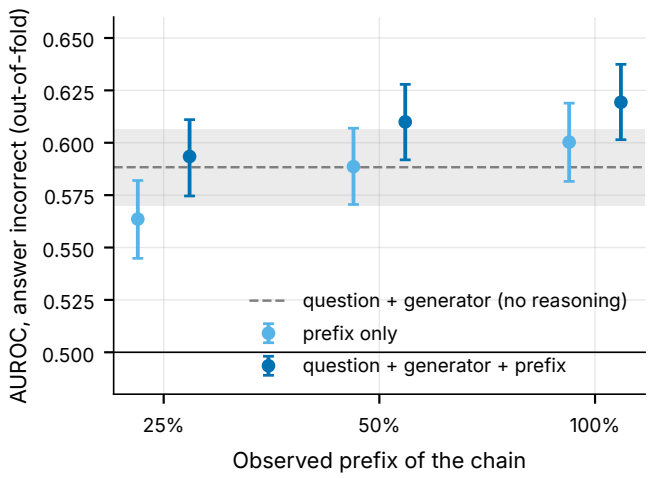


Figure 2: The prefix adds nothing beyond question and generator until half the chain is observed.

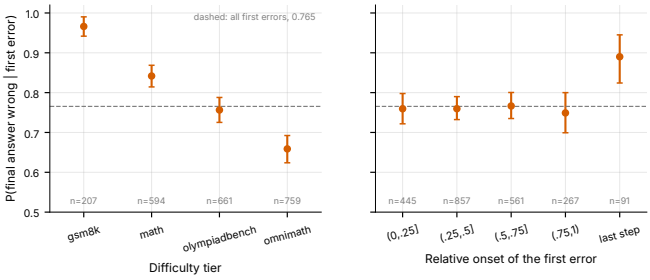


Figure 3: Fatality of first errors by difficulty tier and by where the error occurs.

Fatality falls with difficulty, from 0.966 on GSM8K to 0.659 on Omni-MATH, and is flat in the position of the error (0.749–0.766 across onset quartiles; 0.890 only when the error is in the final step). Fatal and recovered errors occur at the same relative position (Mann–Whitney $p = 0.21$, $r = 0.04$).

Explicit re-checking language after the error is barely more frequent in recovered than in fatal traces (18.6% vs 15.5%, $p = 0.09$), so self-correction does not explain most recoveries. Human coding of a stratified sample of recovered traces by two independent coders is in progress (protocol released); Section 5 measures the same question without coders, by forcing the model to answer at every step.

4.3 Detectors track errors, not commitment

If a failure detector captured commitment, it would score recovered traces like clean ones. It does the opposite (Table 2): trained to predict a wrong answer, the full-prefix detector separates recovered from clean traces (0.703) but ranks fatal traces *below* recovered ones (0.456 [0.428, 0.484]); with question and generator included the ranking is at chance (0.501). A detector trained to find errors inverts more strongly (0.376). Among erroneous traces, the fatality of the first error is predicted by question and generator (AUROC 0.671), and the error step, the prefix up to it or the next one or two steps change this by at most 0.003.

Table 2: AUROC between outcome groups (positive vs negative).

Detector (trained on)	rec. vs clean	fatal vs rec.	fatal vs clean
Prefix 100% (wrong answer)	0.703	0.456	0.664
Q+G+prefix (wrong answer)	0.679	0.501	0.672
Prefix 100% (has error)	0.819	0.376	0.709

5 Counterfactual Commitment

The observational results show that first errors and outcomes come apart. They do not show where a failing trajectory actually becomes unrecoverable. We measure that directly by resampling.

5.1 Setup

Generators and traces. We use four ProcessBench generators whose weights fit on two 16 GB GPUs, from two model families:

- Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct and Qwen2-1.5B-Instruct [24]: all their traces (116 and 88).
- Qwen2.5-Math-7B-Instruct [25]: all fatal and recovered traces with a gold answer, and 60 clean traces (314 in total).
- Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct: the fatal traces completed within the time limit of the confirmatory run (144; Section 3).

The Llama traces cover 512 questions, 479 of which appear in none of the Qwen traces (1,069 distinct questions in total). Gold answers come from the source datasets, matched on problem text, and are compared with `math-verify`.

Rollouts. For every prefix $s_{1:k}$, $k = 0, \ldots, n-1$, we sample m continuations from the trace's own generator with vLLM [26] in float16, at temperature 0.7 and top-p 0.95, and estimate v_k as the fraction that reach the gold answer. The sample sizes are:

- the 1.5B models: $m = 64$, as four independent sampling batches of 16 with different seeds;
- Qwen2.5-Math-7B: $m = 12$;
- Llama: $m = 16$.

Continuations are capped at 1,536 new tokens for the 1.5B models and at 1,024 for the larger models. At the cap, 17% (Qwen2.5-Math-7B) and 29% (Llama) of continuations end without an answer. In total we score 125,832 continuations. Every continuation, its answer and its correctness are released.

What can and cannot be read off v_k. Under the generating policy, v_k is a martingale. Curves conditioned on the eventual outcome therefore drift even when no single step matters: for any fixed k (and any stopping time),

$$\mathbb{E}[v_k \mid \text{fail}] = \frac{\mathbb{E}[v_k(1-v_k)]}{P(\text{fail})} \leq v_0, \qquad (1)$$

because $x(1-x)$ is concave (Appendix A). We therefore never interpret a downward drift of failing curves by itself. We ask whether the drop is *concentrated* at the annotated error, against a position-matched null and the noise floor of clean traces. We evaluate backtracking targets with sample splitting.

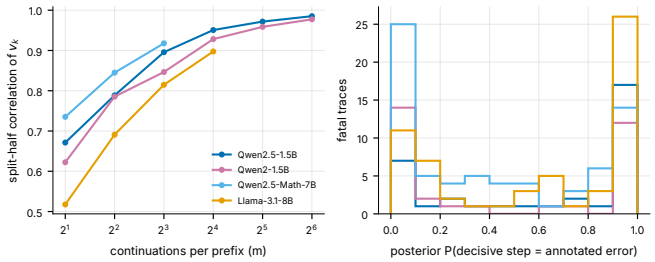


Figure 4: Left: split-half correlation of v_k as a function of the continuations per prefix. Right: posterior probability, per fatal trace, that the decisive step is the annotated first error.

5.2 How precise are the value curves?

Each v_k is a binomial estimate, and the decisive step $d = \arg\max_k(v_{k-1} - v_k)$ is a noisy argmax. We quantify both kinds of uncertainty (Fig. 4).

Value curves. With the four independent batches of the 1.5B models split two against two, v_k correlates at 0.985 and 0.976 across all prefixes (Spearman–Brown projection to $m = 64$: 0.993 and 0.988). The random split-half correlation is 0.951 for Qwen2.5-Math-7B ($m = 12$) and 0.896 for Llama ($m = 16$).

Decisive steps. We draw every v_k from its Jeffreys posterior and recompute d 2,000 times. The modal step has posterior probability at least 0.5 in 94%, 100%, 87% and 88% of the not-capability-limited fatal traces. Independent halves of the continuations pick the same decisive step in 0.765, 0.906, 0.648 and 0.533 of traces, against position-matched nulls of 0.156–0.284. The posterior probability that the decisive step is the annotated error is bimodal: for most traces it is either clearly yes or clearly no. Disagreement between decisive steps and labels is therefore not measurement noise.

5.3 Where failing trajectories commit

Table 3 classifies every fatal trace at $\delta = 1/8$.

Many failures are decided before the first step. 33%, 52%, 66% and 58% of fatal traces are capability-limited: the model solves the problem from scratch at most one time in eight, so no step of the trace is a choke point. This is the counterfactual counterpart of Section 4's difficulty result.

When the outcome is still open, the annotated error is often where it closes. Among fatal traces that are not capability-limited, the first error is the largest drop in v in 0.647, 0.438, 0.423 and 0.633 of traces. The position-matched nulls are 0.166, 0.204, 0.159 and 0.187. The differences are +0.481 [+0.330, +0.627], +0.234 [+0.063, +0.407], +0.264 [+0.154, +0.382] and +0.447 [+0.328, +0.569]. For Llama this was preregistered (C3) and is confirmed. The remaining traces show one of two patterns:

- *latent commitment*: success has already collapsed before the written error (21%, 25%, 18% and 18% of not-capability-limited fatal traces);
- *recoverable errors*: success stays above δ past the error (9%, 22%, 30% and 32%).

Table 3: Where fatal traces commit ($\delta = 1/8$). "Decisive": share of not-capability-limited fatal traces whose largest drop in v is at the annotated first error; null: position-matched. Llama: fatal traces only.

	Qwen2.5-1.5B	Qwen2-1.5B	Qwen2.5-Math-7B	Llama-3.1-8B
Traces (clean/fatal/rec.)	53/51/12	15/67/6	60/207/47	–/144/–
Continuations per prefix	64	64	12	16
Capability-limited	0.333	0.522	0.657	0.583
Latent commitment ($c < e$)	0.137	0.119	0.063	0.076
Commits at error ($c = e$)	0.471	0.254	0.179	0.208
Recoverable error ($c > e$)	0.059	0.104	0.101	0.132
Decisive = first error	0.647	0.438	0.423	0.633
position-matched null	0.166	0.204	0.159	0.187
n	34	32	71	60
Drop at error: fatal	+0.251	+0.162	+0.109	+0.179
Drop at error: recovered	-0.129	+0.211	-0.215	–
Noise floor (clean)	+0.058	+0.201	+0.078	–

Event study. Aligned at the annotated error (Fig. 5), fatal traces show a step change from $r = -1$ to $r = 0$: 0.280→0.029, 0.208→0.046, 0.175→0.066 and 0.241→0.062. Clean traces aligned at a random step drift smoothly upward, as the success-conditioned analogue of Eq. 1 predicts. For recovered traces of Qwen2.5-Math-7B, success *rises* across the annotated error (0.374→0.589), by far more than the drift of clean traces.

Does the model already know its answer? (exploratory) At every prefix we force an immediate answer (65,976 forced answers), giving an *answer curve* a_k. The probe is valid at the endpoints. After the full trace, the forced answer reproduces the trace's own answer in 79–91% of cases for three models, but in only 47% for Qwen2-1.5B, for which the probe is unreliable. From the bare question it is right in 11–14% of cases. Answers become accessible late, mostly after the error position (Fig. 6). In fatal traces, the model's accessible answer was correct just before the error and wrong just after it in only 0.058 (Qwen2.5-Math-7B) and 0.107 (Llama) of traces. In most fatal traces the forced answer was never right (0.850 and 0.824). In recovered traces, the correct answer is already accessible right after the error in 0.340 ($n = 47$) and 0.268 ($n = 97$) of traces. This is a lower bound on recoveries in which the written error did not matter, because answers are computed late even in clean traces.

5.4 Where to backtrack, per attempt

Verifier-guided search resamples a failing trace from some earlier point. We compare four targets on fatal traces:

- restarting from scratch (v_0);
- resampling from just before the annotated first error (v_{e-1});
- resampling from just before the decisive step (v_{d-1});
- the best prefix in hindsight (an in-sample upper bound).

Choosing a step and scoring it on the same continuations would reward noise, so we split every prefix's continuations at random into halves A and B. Half A selects the trace ($v_0^A > \delta$) and its decisive step, and half B scores every target. We average over 50 splits and bootstrap over traces. On a planted-effect simulation in which the first error is the decisive step by construction, this estimator returns $+0.001$, so it does not create a gap.

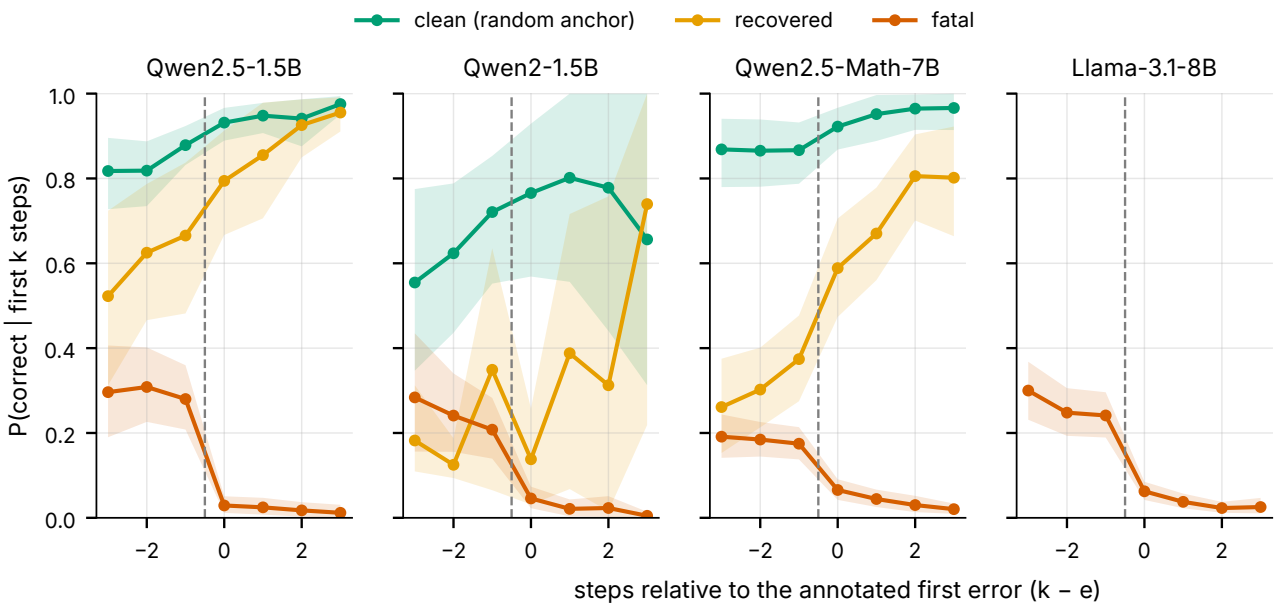


Figure 5: Success probability v_k aligned at the annotated first error ($k - e$; the dashed line separates the last correct step from the error). Shaded: 95% bootstrap CI. Clean traces are aligned at a uniformly drawn step (placebo). Llama: fatal traces only.

Table 4: Success after resampling a fatal trace from each target, per attempt (sample-split, 50 splits; mean pool size in parentheses). 95% trace-bootstrap CIs. Evidence level per row: see Section 3.

	Qwen2.5-1.5B (34)	Qwen2-1.5B (32)	Qwen2.5-Math-7B (76)	Llama-3.1-8B (56)
Restart	0.501	0.575	0.470	0.537
Before annotated first error	0.378	0.410	0.402	0.559
Before decisive step	0.481	0.557	0.511	0.569
Best prefix (oracle, in-sample)	0.549	0.621	0.622	0.678
Restart − first error	+0.123 [+0.054, +0.197]	+0.165 [+0.067, +0.265]	+0.068 [+0.007, +0.133]	-0.022 [-0.090, +0.047]
new batches only (replication)	+0.128 [+0.055, +0.206]	+0.151 [+0.054, +0.249]	–	–
truncated continuations dropped	–	–	+0.107 [+0.044, +0.176]	-0.007 [-0.068, +0.048]
Decisive − first error	+0.103 [+0.053, +0.161]	+0.147 [+0.061, +0.236]	+0.108 [+0.051, +0.165]	+0.010 [-0.030, +0.058]
Decisive − restart	-0.020 [-0.052, +0.013]	-0.018 [-0.061, +0.032]	+0.040 [-0.008, +0.089]	+0.032 [-0.017, +0.085]
TOST at ±0.05 (90% CI)	equivalent	inconclusive	inconclusive	inconclusive
Continuation tokens: restart / decisive	376 / 289	210 / 178	650 / 463	430 / 316

For the three Qwen models, backtracking to the annotated first error is worse than starting over. This was found exploratorily in Run B. Restart beats first-error backtracking by +0.123, +0.165 and +0.068 (Table 4). On the 48 new continuations per prefix alone, which were sampled after the effect was found, it replicates for both 1.5B models. The pooled difference is +0.140 [+0.078, +0.202] (preregistered R1, confirmed). The steps before the error already lower the chance of success. Resampling from just before the decisive step recovers the loss: it beats first-error backtracking by +0.103, +0.147 and +0.108 (all CIs above zero).

For Llama-3.1-8B, it is not. The preregistered confirmatory tests on the new model family fail:

- restart − first error is -0.022 [-0.090, +0.047] (C1, Holm-adjusted $p = 1.00$);
- decisive step − first error is +0.010 [-0.030, +0.058] (C2, Holm-adjusted $p = 1.00$).

This is not an artefact of truncation. With continuations that hit the token limit treated as missing rather than wrong, restart − first error is -0.007 [-0.068, +0.048]. The Llama result is consistent with its localization result: the annotated error is the decisive step more often (0.633), so the step before the error is usually still a good place to resume. Backtracking to human first errors is therefore model-dependent. It is worse than restarting for three Qwen models, but not in general.

Decisive-step backtracking and restart: no difference detected, equivalence mostly untested. Decisive − restart is within ±0.04 for every model, and every 95% CI includes zero. Equivalence at a margin of ±0.05 (TOST, 90% CI) holds for Qwen2.5-1.5B and for the pooled new batches. It is inconclusive for the other models, including the preregistered C4 test on Llama. We therefore do not claim that decisive-step backtracking matches restart; we claim only that no difference was detected. It uses 15–29% fewer continuation tokens per

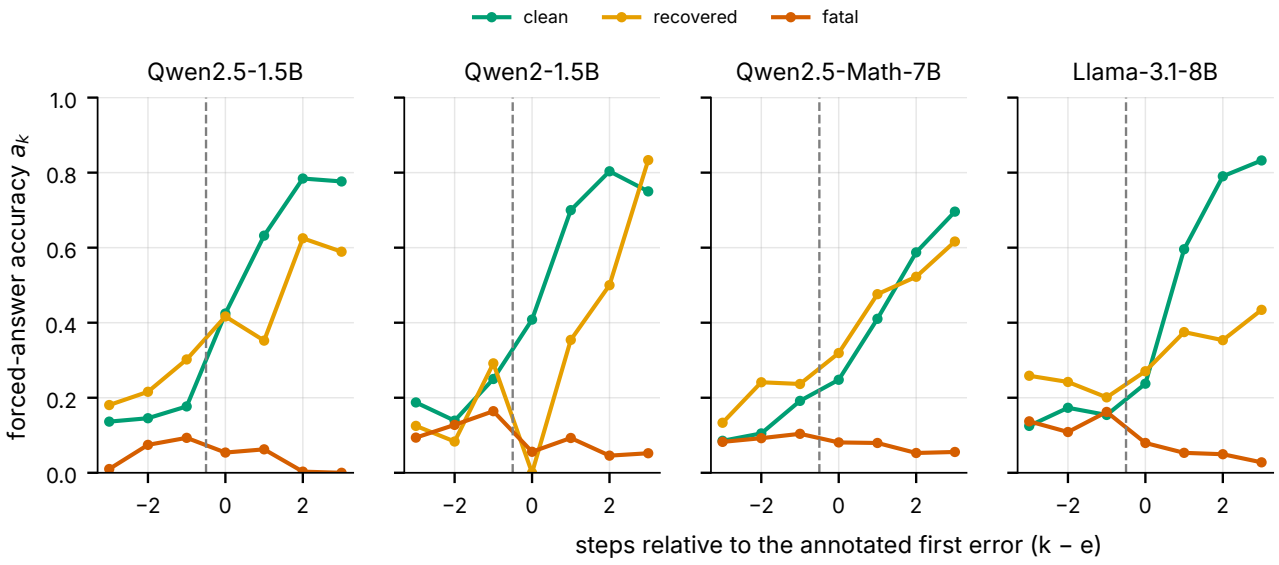


Figure 6: Answer curves: accuracy of an immediately forced answer after k steps, aligned at the annotated first error (clean traces at their middle step).

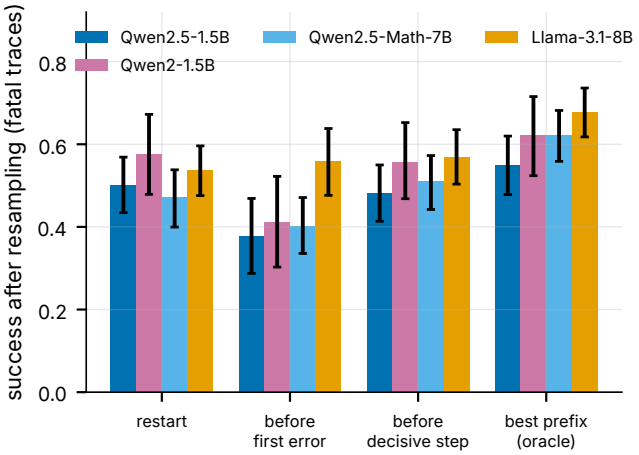


Figure 7: Success after resampling fatal traces from each target (half-B estimates, 50 splits).

attempt. The best prefix in hindsight reaches 0.549–0.678.

Reading. Eq. 1 explains why restart is a strong baseline: for a backtracking point at a fixed depth or at a stopping time of the trace, failed on-policy prefixes are on average no better than the empty prefix. The point just before the first error is neither, because it depends on the next step. So the inequality allows first-error backtracking to beat restart or to lose to it. The data show both outcomes, depending on the model.

6 Practical Policies at a Matched Budget

Section 5.4 compares targets per attempt, using oracle knowledge of the decisive step. A deployed system has to choose a restart point without rollouts and pays for every token. We therefore compare practical policies against restart under a matched end-to-end budget.

Policies. All were fixed before the confirmatory data existed (Section 3).

- Restart.
- PRM first error: resample from before the first step that Qwen2.5-Math-PRM-7B [6] scores below 0.5.
- PRM largest drop: resample from before the step with the largest fall in PRM score.
- Probe search: two probe continuations at each of three prefixes, then resample from the latest prefix with a success.
- Learned: logistic regression on step features (PRM score and drop, the generator's NLL and entropy, position, length), trained to predict the decisive step on the *other* generators. For Llama, it is trained only on the three Qwen models.
- Two references: human first error (the expert label, not available in deployment) and the oracle decisive step (all its rollouts counted).

Implementation check. Our implementation of the verifier loads the reward head directly from the checkpoint. It reaches a ProcessBench F1 of 73.2 over 3,374 traces (GSM8K 81.8, MATH 77.4, OlympiadBench 67.0, Omni-MATH 66.7). The published value is 73.5 [6].

Cost.

- Tokens are weighted by model size relative to the generator (FLOPs $\propto$ parameters $\times$ tokens).
- Every prefill (question plus prefix) counts once per restart point, assuming prefix caching.
- Every generated token counts.
- Verifier passes, probes and oracle rollouts are charged to the policies that use them.
- The budget is b times the cost of one restart attempt, for each trace.
- A policy spends what is left on independent attempts from its restart point. We report the probability that at least one

attempt is correct (Jeffreys-posterior estimate from held-out continuations, 50 splits, trace bootstrap).

No practical policy beats restart reliably (Table 5, Fig. 8).

- **Llama (confirmatory).** PRM largest-drop backtracking is *worse* than restart at four attempts, -0.063 [-0.100, -0.024]. So is the learned policy transferred from Qwen, at -0.187 [-0.226, -0.148].
- **The 1.5B models.** Scoring the trace with a 7B verifier costs about five generator attempts, so every verifier-based policy loses heavily at small budgets.
- **Qwen2.5-Math-7B.** PRM largest-drop backtracking is the only practical policy with a positive estimate. Under full accounting it is -0.022 [-0.052, +0.010] at four attempts and +0.030 [+0.003, +0.057] at eight. If the verifier pass is assumed to be paid anyway, it is +0.046 [+0.017, +0.075] (exploratory).
- **Probe search and the oracle.** Both spend most of the budget on finding the restart point, and lose.

Even a perfect first-error verifier is no shortcut. The human first error, which no deployed system has, is within a few points of restart at matched compute for every model: -0.047, -0.075, +0.039 and +0.001. Later restart points buy more attempts, but each attempt is worth less, which is the trade-off the proposition in Appendix A anticipates.

7 ChokeBench: Grading Localisers on the Target That Matters

ProcessBench grades a verifier by whether it finds the human-labelled first error. The value curves make a second target measurable: the *choke point*, the step where v falls most. ChokeBench grades step localisers on both, and on what the named step is worth as a resampling point. It uses the 230 fatal traces whose outcome is still open ($v_0 > \delta$; effective $n = 199$ after sample splitting) and the released step signals; no model is re-run.

Protocol. A localiser names one step j of a failed trace. We report (i) whether j is the human first error; (ii) the posterior probability that j is the choke point (Jeffreys posterior on every v_k, 2,000 draws), so sampling noise is not counted as a miss; (iii) the per-attempt success of resampling from just before j, minus restart; and (iv) the same difference in P(solved) at a FLOP-matched budget of four restart attempts, *charging nothing for finding* j. Item (iv) is an upper bound on any verifier that uses the localiser; Table 5 charges the verifier. Half of each prefix's continuations select the open traces (and the oracle's choke point), the other half score them, over 50 splits; the estimator reproduces the per-model values of Table 4 within sampling error.

Localisers find errors, not choke points (Table 6, Fig. 9). The PRM's largest-drop rule names the human first error in 73% of open failures, consistent with its ProcessBench F1, but the choke point in only 45% [0.39, 0.51]. The expert label itself is the choke point with probability 0.51. Generator uncertainty (maximum token NLL or entropy) is far below the PRM on both targets, though above a random step. The beginning of the trace is the choke point in 28% of open failures: many of them go wrong on the first step.

Even a perfect localiser buys little. Per attempt, every deployable localiser is worse than restart, from -0.077 to -0.178, and so is the human label (-0.066). With the step found for free and the shorter continuations converted into extra attempts, the human label is still -0.045 [-0.077, -0.013] and the best PRM rule -0.062. An oracle that knows the choke point from held-out rollouts reaches +0.028 [+0.012, +0.046]. That is the ceiling for any backtracking verifier on these traces, before its own cost is paid. It is small because, before the choke point, a failed trace is worth about as much as a fresh start (Appendix A): finding the choke point saves tokens, not successes.

Can a localiser be learned? We train one directly for the choke-point target. Each step of a failed trace becomes an example described by nine features (PRM score, PRM drop, first PRM score below 0.5, mean and maximum token NLL and entropy, step length, relative position), labelled softly with the posterior probability that it is the choke point. The model names the step with the highest predicted probability. Evaluation is leave-one-generator-out, with nested selection: for each held-out generator, 24 configurations (logistic regression with $C \in \{0.01, 0.1, 1, 10\}$ and gradient-boosted trees with depth $\in \{2, 3\}$ and learning rate $\in \{0.05, 0.2\}$, each on PRM, generator or all features) are scored by leave-one-generator-out cross-validation on the other three generators only, and the best is refit and tested once (Fig. 10). The tuned localiser finds the choke point with probability 0.39 [0.33, 0.44], no better than the fixed PRM rules, and its restart point is worth -0.071 at a 4× budget. Inner-CV scores do not carry over to the held-out model (best inner score 0.51 vs test 0.25 for Qwen2.5-Math-7B): which step decides a failure is model-specific, as the transfer failure of the learned restart policy in Section 6 already suggested.

Release. `results/chokebench/chokebench_v1.jsonl` holds, for every failed trace, the per-prefix success counts, continuation counts and lengths, the human label and the PRM scores. A new localiser is graded by naming one step per trace (`scripts/49_chokebench.py`).

8 The Same Question for Hallucinations

Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) offers what mathematics lacks: a detector can check, while the system runs, whether each sentence is supported by the source. If hallucinations were choke points, a controller that estimates v_k online and resamples from the most recoverable boundary should beat plain restarting. We built such a controller and preregistered its test (`docs/PREREGISTRATION_RECOVERY.md`, committed before any data).

Setup. RAGTruth [30] test sources (450; QA, summarisation, data-to-text), whose Llama-2-7B-chat responses carry human span labels, and 300 HotpotQA [34] items with controlled evidence (half with the answer removed). The gate

Table 5: P(solved) minus restart for fatal traces at a budget of four restart attempts (FLOP-matched, all overheads charged). 95% trace-bootstrap CIs. "Shared verifier": the PRM pass is not charged, as if it had been run anyway to detect the failure (exploratory). Llama rows are confirmatory for PRM largest drop and Learned; all other rows are exploratory.

	Qwen2.5-1.5B	Qwen2-1.5B	Qwen2.5-Math-7B	Llama-3.1-8B
Restart: P(solved)	0.657	0.514	0.437	0.492
PRM first error	-0.651 [-0.744, -0.558]	-0.514 [-0.603, -0.424]	-0.041 [-0.066, -0.016]	-0.068 [-0.102, -0.035]
PRM largest drop	-0.651 [-0.744, -0.558]	-0.514 [-0.603, -0.424]	-0.022 [-0.052, +0.010]	-0.063 [-0.100, -0.024]
Probe search	-0.646 [-0.739, -0.554]	-0.448 [-0.537, -0.361]	-0.428 [-0.468, -0.388]	-0.489 [-0.539, -0.436]
Learned	-0.657 [-0.749, -0.563]	-0.514 [-0.603, -0.424]	-0.151 [-0.177, -0.127]	-0.187 [-0.226, -0.148]
Human first error (reference)	-0.047 [-0.122, +0.027]	-0.075 [-0.132, -0.022]	+0.039 [+0.012, +0.066]	+0.001 [-0.025, +0.029]
Oracle decisive step, rollouts counted	-0.657	-0.514	-0.437	-0.492
PRM largest drop, shared verifier	-0.061 [-0.146, +0.022]	-0.098 [-0.160, -0.040]	+0.046 [+0.017, +0.075]	+0.003 [-0.030, +0.036]

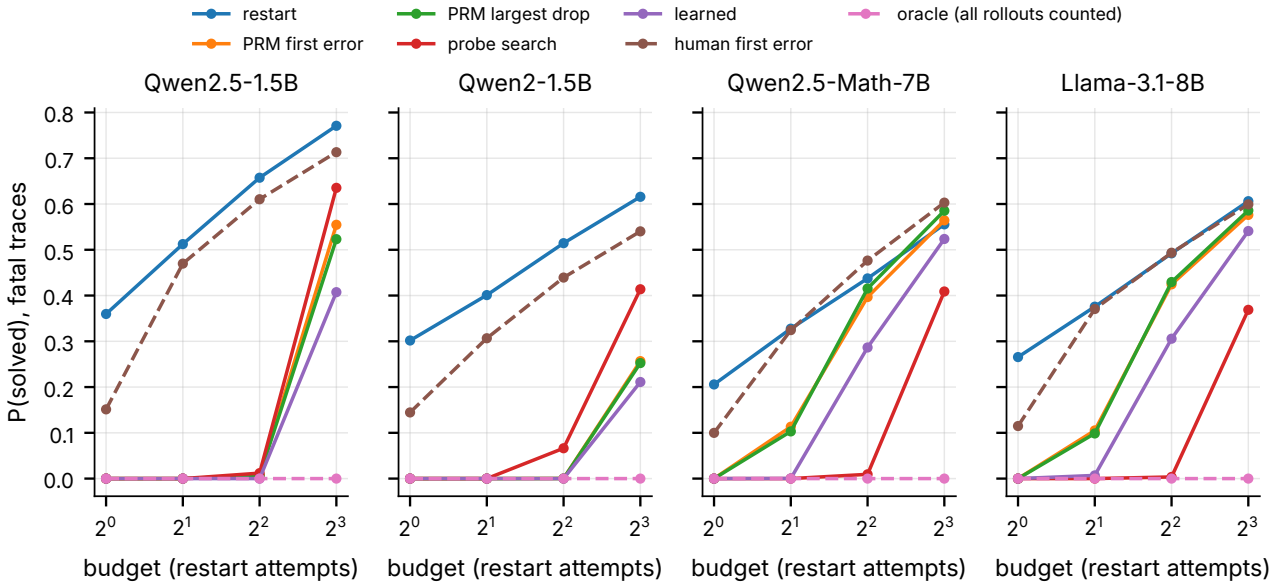


Figure 8: P(solved) for fatal traces against the end-to-end budget (in restart attempts, FLOP-matched, all overheads charged).

D is LettuceDetect-base [31]. When D flags a sentence, the controller (CARE) tries claim repair, then resamples, choosing between restarting and backtracking to just before the flagged sentence by Thompson sampling on each boundary's estimated recoverability per token, then abstains (QA) or deletes what is still flagged. Every policy replays the same bank of on-policy continuations (9,696 in the mechanism study alone), under a budget cap of $b = 2$ draft-equivalents; tokens actually spent are reported. The preregistered primary evaluator E_1 is an LLM judge from another family (Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct; $\kappa = 0.219$ with RAGTruth's human labels, passing the preregistered bar of 0.20); E_2 (LettuceDetect-large) is secondary because it shares training data with D.

Preregistered results (RAGTruth).

- *H0, sanity:* CARE reduces hallucination relative to the base model, -0.047 [-0.072, -0.025] ($p = 0.0003$).
- *H1, versus restart until D passes:* -0.005 [-0.024, +0.013]; equivalent within ± 0.03 (TOST 90% CI [-0.021, +0.010]). Restart spends 1,293 tokens per item against 1,677 for CARE.
- *H5, does the commitment-aware choice add anything?* CARE minus the same controller restricted to restarts: -0.000 [-0.005, +0.005] under E_1 and +0.003 [-0.004, +0.010] under E_2. An oracle that knows each boundary's true recoverability gains -0.015 [-0.027, -0.004]: there was little to choose between.
- *Mechanism, with human span labels:* over 226 human-hallucinated drafts, resampling from just before the first hallucinated sentence is no better than restarting (+0.024 [-0.002, +0.049], $p = 0.066$; +0.093 for summaries, exploratory). Keeping a hallucinated sentence does not raise the hazard of later ones relative to a placebo (-0.006 [-0.029, +0.019]): no snowballing [35].

HotpotQA agrees: H0 holds and no comparison against an alternative strategy is significant.

Who grades the loop matters (exploratory). Detector-gated policies resample until D is satisfied, so an evaluator that resembles D will tend to agree that they succeeded. We score every RAGTruth policy on the 232 sources of a held-out half under five evaluators (Table 7). One of them never reads

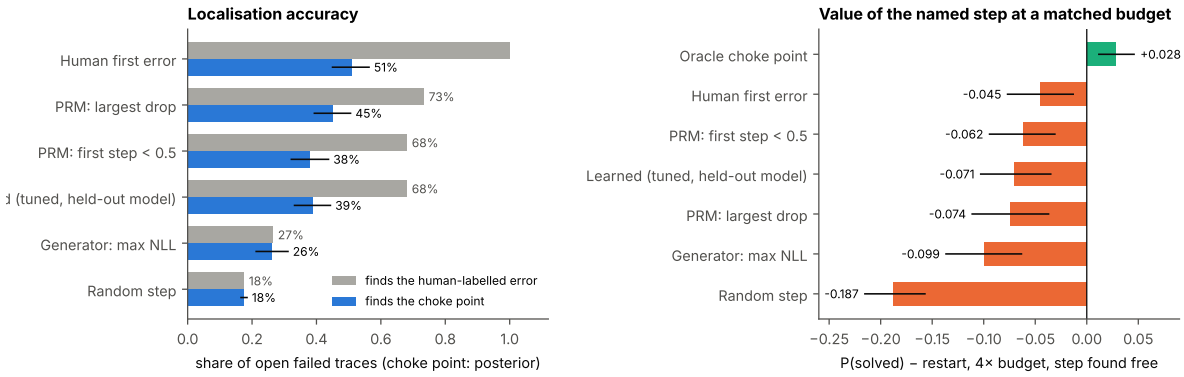


Figure 9: ChokeBench. Left: PRM rules find human-labelled errors far more often than choke points. Right: P(solved) minus restart at a budget of four restart attempts when finding the step is free.

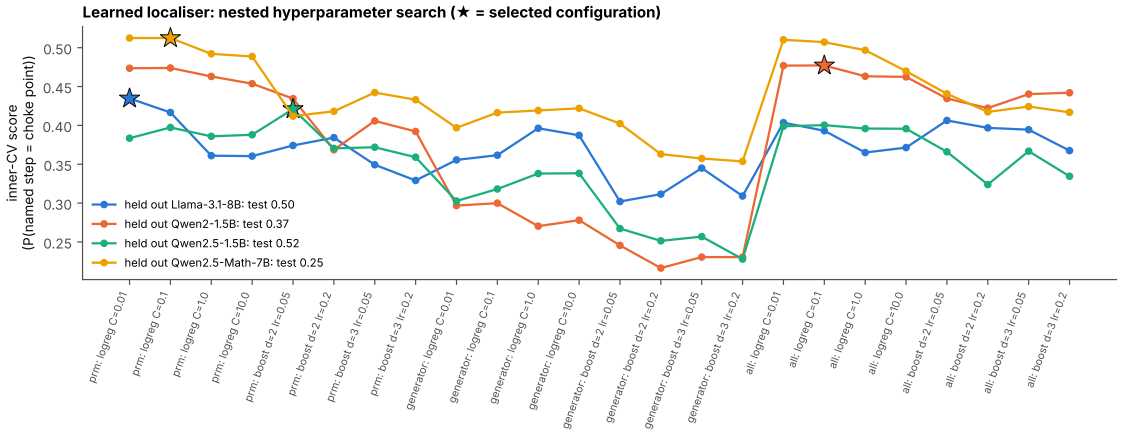


Figure 10: Nested hyperparameter selection of the learned localiser. Each line is one outer fold (held-out generator); points are inner leave-one-generator-out scores of the 24 configurations; stars mark the selected configuration; the legend gives its score on the held-out generator.

a LettuceDetect score: E_1 with a threshold on the share of sentences it calls unsupported (25%), chosen on the other 216 drafts from a grid fixed in advance. Its human agreement is weak ($\kappa = 0.189$ on the held-out drafts), like E_1's (0.238); E_2, the "dual" rule $E_1 \wedge E_2 \geq 0.3$ and D agree better (0.535, 0.560, 0.476) but share training data with the gate (E_2 agrees with D on 85.0% of drafts, E_1-calibrated on 58.9%). The threshold 0.3 of the dual rule was chosen on all drafts, so its held-out κ is not an out-of-sample estimate.

Two conclusions survive the change of evaluator: CARE beats restart under none of the five, and it matches its restart-only ablation under both preregistered evaluators (H5). Everything else depends on the evaluator. Restarting until D passes lowers the hallucination rate by +0.326 according to E_2 and +0.309 according to the dual rule, but by +0.017 [-0.013, +0.047] according to E_1 and +0.013 [-0.043, +0.069] according to its calibrated version. Chain-of-Verification [32], which never consults D, looks far worse than restart to the D-family (+0.235 under the dual rule) and indistinguishable from it to the independent judges (+0.031 [-0.031, +0.092]). The independent judges are weak, so they cannot rule out a real reduction; but the D-family numbers are partly the gate grading itself. Gains of a verifier loop should be measured by an evaluator that shares no training data with the verifier, and ultimately by people (a blinded two-rater kit is released; Section 10).

Reading. As in mathematics, the step where the output first goes wrong is a fine but not a better place to resume than the beginning, and an online estimate of recoverability does not change that. Hallucinations here behave like local errors rather than commitments: detecting and resampling them reduces hallucination by an amount the evaluators disagree on, and choosing where to resample adds nothing.

9 Discussion

For early warning. Reported AUROCs for early failure prediction should come with a question-only baseline, a generator baseline, the increment over both, and a within-problem concordance. Without them, a detector of problem difficulty

Table 6: ChokeBench, pooled over four generators. Accuracy on the human first error (Human) and on the choke point (Choke, posterior); success minus restart per attempt and at a 4× budget with free localisation. 95% trace-bootstrap CIs in Fig. 9.

Localiser	Human	Choke	Δ/attempt	Δ at 4×
Human first error	1.00	0.51	-0.066	-0.045
PRM: first step < 0.5	0.68	0.38	-0.077	-0.062
PRM: largest drop	0.73	0.45	-0.103	-0.074
PRM: minimum	0.61	0.39	-0.158	-0.121
Generator: max token NLL	0.27	0.26	-0.097	-0.099
Generator: max entropy	0.30	0.28	-0.178	-0.165
Random step	0.18	0.18	-0.224	-0.187
First step (= restart)	0.14	0.28	+0.000	+0.000
Learned, tuned (held-out model)	0.68	0.39	-0.085	-0.071
Oracle choke point (split)	–	–	+0.015	+0.028

Table 7: Hallucination rate (%) on the held-out half of RAGTruth under five evaluators. D-family evaluators share LettuceDetect's training data with the gate. Differences from restart with 95% CIs: `results/recovery/final/evaluator_robustness.md`.

			independent of D		D-family		
Policy	Cov.	Tokens	E_1	E_1-cal.	E_2	dual	D
Base model	100.0	980	80.7	51.1	47.2	49.8	44.6
Restart until D passes	99.6	1,320	79.0	49.8	14.6	18.9	0.9
Backtrack until D passes	99.6	1,279	80.3	52.8	19.3	26.2	0.4
CARE	97.1	1,708	77.7	46.8	19.3	24.9	2.1
CARE, restarts only	96.8	1,710	77.3	45.1	18.5	23.6	2.1
Abstain if flagged (QA)	88.4	1,001	67.8	42.1	15.0	19.7	5.6
CoVe, revised answer (n=98)	100.0	–	71.4	43.9	41.8	42.9	30.6

cannot be told apart from a detector of reasoning failure. On ProcessBench, text detectors pass this test only after half the chain. The counterfactual measurement explains why. Between 33% and 66% of failures are fixed before the first step, so reading the trajectory can add little for them.

For process supervision. Human first-error labels mark where reasoning first goes wrong, which is the right target for auditing. They are also, more often than chance, where success collapses: 0.423–0.647 of open failures, confirmed on a new model family. But using them as restart points depends on the model. Per attempt it was worse than restarting for three Qwen models and equal for Llama, and at matched compute it never clearly beat restarting. Verifier-guided backtracking should therefore always be reported against restart at matched end-to-end compute, with the verifier's own cost included.

What would change the picture. The in-sample oracle shows apparent headroom: the best restart point in hindsight succeeds 0.549–0.678 per attempt, against 0.470–0.575 for restart. ChokeBench shows that most of it is selection on noise: chosen and scored on independent halves of the rollouts, the choke point is worth +0.015 per attempt and +0.028 at a 4× budget, before any verifier cost. Backtracking can win only where a prefix holds work the model cannot reproduce from scratch, which is the regime of long, correct-so-far reasoning [11] and of deep search problems [36], not of failed traces at these scales. The released value curves let anyone test a localiser against that ceiling.

For grounded generation. The math result carries over: the first hallucinated sentence is not a better resampling point than the beginning, an online recoverability estimate does not change that, and hallucinations do not snowball. A detector-gated loop does reduce hallucination, but by how much depends on whether the evaluator resembles the gate. We recommend that recovery systems report (i) a matched-compute restart baseline, (ii) an ablation that removes the choice of resampling point, and (iii) an evaluator that shares no training data with the gate.

10 Limitations and what remains unverified

- **Coverage.**
  - Four open models of at most 8B parameters, mathematics only.
  - Llama contributes 144 fatal traces. Its recovered and clean traces were not run, so Llama has no noise floor, no event study for those groups, and no answer-curve comparison by rollout.
  - Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct and larger models were not run.
- **On-policy approximation.** ProcessBench re-segmented the original solutions, and the decoding settings that produced them are unknown. Prefixes are therefore near-, not exactly, on-policy, and the proposition holds only approximately for them.
- **Truncation.** For the larger models, 17% and 29% of continuations hit the token cap without an answer. Treating them as missing changes no conclusion, but it lowers absolute success rates.
- **Equivalence.** Equivalence of decisive-step backtracking and restart at ± 0.05 is established only for Qwen2.5-1.5B and the pooled new batches. Elsewhere, including the pre-registered Llama test, it is inconclusive.
- **Exploratory results.** The difficulty and fatality analyses, the answer curves, the shared-verifier accounting and all policy results on the Qwen models are exploratory.
- **Human coding.** The coding of recovered traces by two independent human coders has not been done. The protocol and blinded sheets are released, and no coding result is reported.
- **Hallucination recovery.** One generator (Llama-2-7B-chat); the Llama-3.1-8B arm produced drafts only (GPU quota), so no recovery claim is made for it. Chain-of-Verification ran on 192 of 750 items. The independent judges agree only weakly with people, and no human rating of the system's outputs exists yet; a blinded 80-pair, two-rater kit is released.
- **ChokeBench** is built from the same rollouts as Sections 5–6 and is exploratory; its localisers are fixed rules, not trained models (the learned policy of Section 6 is the trained case).

11 Conclusion

Errors are where generation first goes wrong; choke points are where it stops being recoverable. Measured counterfactually, with preregistration and independent replication, four things hold. Many failures are decided before the first step, which is why early warning reads difficulty. When the outcome is still open, the human-labelled error is a better-than-chance but imperfect locator of the choke point, and process reward models track the label rather than the choke point. Neither labels, nor reward models, nor an oracle for the choke point provide a resampling point that clearly beats starting over at matched compute. And the same is true for hallucinations in retrieval-augmented generation. Restart is the baseline that local recovery has to beat, and the gains, where there are any, lie in the verifier and the evaluator, not in where one resamples.

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A Why restarting is a strong baseline

Let a trace $s_1, \ldots, s_n$ be sampled from policy M for question q, let S be the event that its final answer is correct, $\mathcal{F}_k = \sigma(s_{1:k})$, and $v_k = P_M(S \mid q, \mathcal{F}_k)$. Resampling a fresh continuation of $s_{1:k}$ from M succeeds with probability v_k.

Proposition. For every stopping time $\tau \leq n$ of $(\mathcal{F}_k)$, $\mathbb{E}[v_\tau \mid \neg S] \leq v_0$ (whenever $v_0 < 1$).

Proof. (v_k) is a bounded martingale and $g(x) = x(1-x)$ is concave, so $g(v_k)$ is a bounded supermartingale; by optional stopping $\mathbb{E}[g(v_\tau)] \leq g(v_0)$. By the tower property, $\mathbb{E}[v_\tau \mathbf{1}_{\neg S}] = \mathbb{E}[v_\tau(1-v_\tau)] = \mathbb{E}[g(v_\tau)]$. Dividing by $P(\neg S) = 1 - v_0$ gives $\mathbb{E}[v_\tau \mid \neg S] \leq v_0(1-v_0)/(1-v_0) = v_0$. □

Consequences. (i) Any backtracking rule that picks its restart point by reading the failed trace only up to that point (a fixed depth, a confidence threshold crossed so far, a verifier that flags step k using $s_{1:k}$ and resamples from k) cannot, per attempt and in expectation over failed on-policy traces, beat restarting from scratch. (ii) Rules that look ahead can: resampling from *before* a flagged step uses step $k+1$, and the decisive step uses rollouts. The proposition therefore sets the bar a backtracking target must clear, and the paper measures how far human first errors and verifier signals clear it. (iii) The proposition is per attempt. Under a fixed compute budget a later restart point buys more attempts, because continuations are shorter, which is why Section 6 compares policies at a matched end-to-end budget. (iv) ProcessBench traces were not necessarily sampled at the temperature used for v_k, so the proposition holds only approximately for them; the empirical comparisons do not rely on it.

B Preregistered tests and outcomes

Test	Hypothesis (data)	Estimate [95% CI]	Outcome
H1	first error is the decisive step more often than chance (Qwen, Run B)	see Table 3	supported (Qwen2-1.5B CI includes null at $m = 16$)
C1	restart > first-error backtracking (Llama)	-0.022 [-0.090, +0.047]	not confirmed
C2	decisive-step > first-error backtracking (Llama)	+0.010 [-0.030, +0.058]	not confirmed
C3	decisive share > position-matched null (Llama)	+0.447 [+0.328, +0.569]	confirmed (Holm-adjusted p <0.002)
C4	decisive-step ≡ restart within ± 0.05 (Llama)	90%: [-0.008, +0.076]	inconclusive
R1	restart > first error on new batches only (Qwen 1.5B, pooled)	+0.140 [+0.078, +0.202]	confirmed
R2	v_k reliable across independent batches	$r = 0.985$, 0.976	confirmed
R3	decisive step stable under posterior noise	modal ≥ 0.5: 94%, 100%	confirmed
P2, P4	practical policies vs restart at $b = 4$ (Llama)	-0.063, -0.187	both worse than restart

C Threshold and definition sensitivity

	Qwen2.5-1.5B	Qwen2-1.5B	Qwen2.5-Math-7B	Llama-3.1-8B
Restart − first error, $\delta = 1/16$	+0.112	+0.155	+0.068	-0.011
Restart − first error, $\delta = 1/8$	+0.123	+0.165	+0.068	-0.022
Restart − first error, $\delta = 1/4$	+0.136	+0.186	+0.116	-0.031
First error = largest drop, $\delta = 1/16$ / $1/8$ / $1/4$	0.561 / 0.647 / 0.633	0.405 / 0.438 / 0.481	0.386 / 0.423 / 0.404	0.621 / 0.633 / 0.706
First error = point of no return	0.634 / 0.706 / 0.600	0.568 / 0.531 / 0.556	0.477 / 0.521 / 0.489	0.455 / 0.500 / 0.588
First error = first drop above clean floor	0.390 / 0.471 / 0.467	0.216 / 0.250 / 0.296	0.205 / 0.239 / 0.277	–

Restart − first error keeps its sign and significance at every threshold for every model: positive for the three Qwen models and null for Llama. The clean-floor definition is unavailable for Llama (no clean traces were run).